



Missionary zeal

The Islamic religion and culture did not remain confined to the Middle East. Having been spread mainly by missionaries and trade contacts, by the 15th century it had traveled as far east as Indonesia and the Philippines.

KEY

- Islamic world in 1200
- Spread of Islam 1200–1450



Preacher of Islam

People who lived under Islamic rule were not forced to convert. Many were converted by traveling preachers such as the one depicted in this 13th-century manuscript.

daughter Fatima, emerged from Tunisia to take over North Africa and claim the title of caliph. 'Ubaydallah's "Fatimid" descendants conquered Egypt in 969, and founded the city of Cairo. From there they went on to conquer Syria and Palestine, reaching as far as Aleppo and Damascus. The Fatimid caliph ordered the destruction of the Church of the Holy Sepulcher in Jerusalem, causing uproar in Europe and helping trigger the Crusades (see pp.200–01).

Cairo, meanwhile, became the center for a trade network that extended throughout the Mediterranean, the Red Sea, and the Indian Ocean. Goods such as porcelain from China and spices from Southeast Asia were brought in by ship to the Egyptian Red Sea ports. Gold and slaves, meanwhile, were brought down the Nile from Ethiopia and the Sudan, to be traded in Cairo.

Alhambra palace

The Alhambra was built in the 14th century at Granada in southern Spain. The palace buildings are covered in tiles and plasterwork bearing Islamic geometric designs and inscriptions.

AL- The Arabic word for "the" forms the prefix of many scientific words that were adopted by medieval Europe along with the scientific knowledge of the Islamic world—for example, alkali, algebra, alchemy, algorithm, and almanac.

Most of the merchants were Muslim, although some Europeans from Venice and Genoa were also involved.

As well as being an important trading center, Cairo was also a site of religious learning. Al-Azhar University, founded by the Fatimids in the 10th century, is one of the oldest universities in existence. It attracted scholars from

ABBASID CALIPH

HARUN AL-RASHID

Harun al-Rashid was the fifth Abbasid caliph, ruling in Baghdad from 786–809. He is famous as a protagonist in many of the stories of *The Book of One Thousand and One Nights* (the "Arabian Nights"), but was also a significant historical figure.

Harun was the first caliph to appoint a vizier (from the Arabic *wazir*, meaning "helper") with many administrative powers—although his own vizier was removed from power in 803. He was also an important patron of the arts, presiding over part of the "Golden Age" that saw the emergence of classical Islamic culture.



Although the Islamic world was united by culture and trade throughout the whole medieval period, it did not always have one government. As the Abbasid dynasty concentrated its power in the east, the areas farthest from the new caliphate began to break away. First was Spain, which in 756 became an independent emirate, or principality, ruled by a branch of the exiled Umayyad dynasty. Shortly after this, independent governors also arose in Morocco, western and eastern Algeria, Tunisia, and Egypt.

By the 10th century, Islam had developed into three separate caliphates—the title "caliph" was by

now taken by the self-appointed head of any major Islamic community who felt the right to take it. In addition to the Abbasids in Baghdad, there was a Fatimid caliphate in Egypt, and an Umayyad caliphate in Spain.

The Isma'ili Fatimids

The Fatimid dynasty was founded in the early 10th century by an Isma'ili Shia Muslim named 'Ubaydallah. The Isma'ili Shia branch of Islam probably started as a secret movement in Iraq, though its missionary activity soon took its members all across the Islamic world. In 910 'Ubaydallah, who claimed descent from Muhammad's